

HCM Customer Pain Points: Market Analysis

Oracle FDI HCM | Workday HCM | SMB HCM (Rippling, BambooHR, Gusto) + Cross-Vendor Analysis

Prepared: May 2026 (revised) • Desk research across publicly available customer review summaries, analyst commentary, and regulatory trackers

Executive Summary

This analysis is based on desk research across publicly available customer review summaries, analyst commentary, vendor partner write-ups, and regulatory trackers, covering three distinct HCM segments. Each pain point reflects a theme that surfaced consistently across multiple independent sources; single anecdotes were excluded. The three segments carry different pain profiles shaped by buyer size, deployment model, and product maturity. Oracle FDI HCM customers struggle primarily with analytics extensibility and implementation complexity tied to Fusion HCM data structures. Workday HCM customers cite cost, UX friction, and rigid configuration. SMB HCM customers (Rippling, BambooHR, Gusto) most frequently complain about support gaps, payroll/tax errors, pricing opacity, and feature limitations as they scale.

Sections 4–6 add a cross-vendor analysis: the five most painful HCM subject areas across the entire customer base, a deep-dive into the specific HR analytics domain that drives the most reported pain (with a direct comparison of Performance vs. Attrition vs. Payroll Analytics), and a correction of the common misconception that compliance pain is exclusively a payroll problem.

This May 2026 revision refreshes the workforce-planning evidence base with current-year survey data (OrgChart 2026, Gartner 2026 CHRO Survey) and adds 2026 developments on the EU Pay Transparency Directive transposition, the EU AI Act Digital Omnibus, and US state PFML expansion.

1. Oracle FDI HCM Customers — Top 10 Pain Points

Buyer profile: Large enterprises running Oracle Fusion Cloud HCM who licensed Fusion Data Intelligence (FDI, formerly FAW) for analytics. Pain points cluster around extensibility, semantic model complexity, data security, and OOTB content fit.

1. Out-of-the-box content often does not fit customer needs

Customers report having to rebuild large portions of prebuilt FDI content because standard reports, KPIs and subject areas do not reflect their specific HR data model, hierarchies, or business definitions.

Source: Gartner Peer Insights — Oracle Fusion Data Intelligence reviews

2. Steep learning curve and dependence on technical expertise

Configuring semantic models, building custom dimensions and metrics, and extending pipelines requires Oracle-specific BI skills (OAC, ADW, semantic model extensions) that most HR teams do not possess in-house.

Source: Gartner Peer Insights — Oracle FDI reviews; Oracle Community FDI threads (Feb 2026)

3. Occasional data sync and accuracy problems

Verified reviewers describe periodic data refresh inconsistencies between Fusion HCM source and the FDI Autonomous Data Warehouse, eroding trust in dashboards used for executive decisions.

Source: Gartner Peer Insights — Oracle Fusion Data Intelligence

4. Challenging setup, migration, and version transitions

FDI implementations are often disrupted by version changes (e.g., FDR v1 production go-live not supported mid-implementation) and pipeline deprecations announced via in-product notifications, forcing customers into unplanned rework.

Source: Oracle Community — Oracle Analytics / Fusion Data Intelligence forum threads (Feb 2026)

5. PII handling and data security configuration is heavy lifting

HCM data is sensitive by nature. Customers spend significant effort hiding personally identifiable information, configuring HCM Business Unit Data Security roles, and implementing custom data security — and report that documented nine-step procedures fail in practice.

Source: Gartner Peer Insights; Oracle Community FDI HCM data security thread (June 2024)

6. Documentation gaps

Reviewers explicitly call out a lack of documentation as a barrier to self-service adoption, particularly for HCM Analytics extensibility, custom security, and semantic model extensions.

Source: Gartner Peer Insights — Oracle Fusion Data Intelligence

7. Fragmented data across Fusion pillars (ERP, SCM, HCM)

Even within Oracle's own stack, customers struggle to deliver cross-pillar executive KPIs because HCM analytics are licensed and modeled separately from ERP and SCM analytics.

Source: Trinamix Oracle FDI partner site (Nov 2025)

8. Slow, resource-intensive creation of custom reports beyond OOTB

Custom KPIs, metrics, and reports are technically supported but practically slow to build, requiring partner consulting time. This is the same gap that drove customers to FDI from OTBI in the first place.

Source: Trinamix partner site (Nov 2025); Apps Associates blog (June 2025)

9. No formatted P&L / Balance Sheet financial statements out of the box

While not HCM-only, customers running integrated workforce-cost analytics find that FDI does not ship with formatted Balance Sheet or Income Statement reports. Aggregation logic must be defined and built per chart of accounts.

Source: Apps Associates — Lessons Learned after 20 FDI Implementations (June 2025)

10. Adoption fails when stakeholders don't feel a clear pain point

Implementation partners explicitly warn that FDI rollouts fall flat when business users have not articulated a reporting problem in advance, indicating that change management and use-case discovery are recurring failure modes.

Source: Apps Associates blog (June 2025)

2. Workday HCM Customers — Top 10 Pain Points

Buyer profile: Mid-market and enterprise organizations (typically 1,000+ employees) using Workday's unified HR/payroll/talent platform. Pain points cluster around cost, UX friction, configuration rigidity, and support model.

1. High and opaque total cost of ownership

Custom enterprise pricing with software fees that customer reviews indicate fall in the range of roughly \$30–\$45 PEPM, and one-time implementation fees historically running comparable to or above annual software fees.

Source: Outsail Workday Reviews; Skima.ai Workday HCM Review 2026; GetApp

2. Lengthy, resource-intensive implementations

Enterprise Workday implementations typically take many months, with full deployments commonly cited at the 9–18 month range. Even Launch Express is reported as too fast for 500+ employee companies.

Source: HR Technology Advice; Outsail; Research.com Workday HCM Review 2026

3. Steep learning curve and clunky UX

Reviewers describe routine tasks as requiring excessive clicks, multiple page redirects, and cluttered menus with jargon.

Source: G2 Workday HCM reviews; Capterra; Software Advice

4. Limited customization and rigid configuration

Customers report that workflows feel rigid, configuration changes require deep system knowledge, and Studio integrations require coding.

Source: G2 Workday HCM reviews; Research.com Workday HCM Review 2026

5. Slow customer support and ticket-based resolution

Smaller Workday customers are routed through third-party support partners. Users report lengthy ticket response times measured in days, not hours.

Source: GetApp Workday HCM support analysis; Software Advice; Capterra

6. Reporting and analytics complexity

Large customers cite slow report response times, page load delays, and limited customization for advanced reporting.

Source: Skima.ai Workday HCM Review 2026; Software Advice reviews

7. Recruiting (ATS) module weaker than specialized tools

Workday's ATS is built to feed hires into the HRIS, not to optimize sourcing.

Source: Skima.ai Workday HCM Review 2026; G2

8. Mobile experience gaps

Reviewers cite sign-on issues, an unintuitive mobile app, and feature parity gaps with desktop.

Source: G2 Workday Compensation reviews; Skima.ai

9. Community and roadmap concerns under recent strategy shift

Long-tenured Workday administrators have publicly criticized the removal of historical Community content, the elimination of regular Next Levels, and a shift toward Agent AI features.

Source: G2 Workday HCM verified user reviews

10. Implementation methodology often rushed, leading to rework

Customers report Launch Express timelines leave too little time for data audit, configuration, and testing — resulting in modules being reconfigured entirely after go-live.

Source: HR Technology Advice — Workday HCM customer testimonials

3. SMB HCM Customers (Rippling, BambooHR, Gusto) — Top 10 Pain Points

Buyer profile: Small and mid-sized businesses (typically <500 employees) using consumer-grade, fast-deploy HR/payroll platforms. Pain points cluster around support quality, payroll/tax accuracy, pricing opacity, and feature ceilings as customers scale.

1. Customer support quality and access

Gusto: AI-bot loops, no path to assigned specialists, lengthy email threads per issue. Rippling: chatbot-first triage, live support restricted to admins only. BambooHR: inconsistent email domains, hard-to-reach agents.

Source: BBB Gusto complaints (2025–2026); Connecteam Rippling review (Jan 2025); Trustpilot BambooHR

2. Payroll and tax-filing failures with material customer impact

Gusto BBB complaints document failed quarterly tax filings, NSF events, W-2-C errors customers paid outside accountants to fix, and charges for next-day payroll the system could not deliver.

Source: BBB Gusto customer reviews & complaints; Trustpilot Gusto

3. Pricing opacity and add-on cost creep

Rippling: implementation fees in the mid-single to low-double-digit percentage range of annual contract value, frequently not disclosed upfront. Gusto: per-employee fees rise quickly with add-ons. BambooHR: premium add-ons (performance, compensation) significantly increase total cost.

Source: HRStacks Rippling Review 2026; Capterra Gusto; Juicebox.ai BambooHR Reviews 2026

4. Limited customization for complex workflows

BambooHR: easy but inflexible — limited custom fields, rigid time-off accruals. Gusto: limited reporting customization. Both struggle as companies cross the lower-mid-market threshold.

Source: G2 BambooHR reviews; Capterra BambooHR; Outsail; Capterra Gusto

5. Reporting and analytics weakness

Rippling reports called extremely difficult to build. BambooHR forces spreadsheet exports for deep analysis. Gusto reporting limited vs. dedicated HR platforms.

Source: Capterra Rippling; Juicebox.ai BambooHR Reviews 2026; Capterra Gusto

6. Steep learning curve from all-in-one breadth (especially Rippling)

Rippling's breadth (HR + IT + finance + spend) creates initial admin complexity.

Source: Capterra Rippling reviews; HRStacks Rippling Review 2026

7. Integration and feature gaps as customers scale

BambooHR's ATS viewed as an afterthought. Rippling lacks a true rehire process and leave-of-absence mechanism. Gusto's reporting and mobile manager experience lag dedicated HR platforms.

Source: SelectSoftware Reviews — BambooHR Expert Review 2026; G2 Rippling; Capterra Gusto

8. Mobile app limitations

BambooHR's mobile app slow and missing features. Rippling's mobile app occasionally buggy. Gusto's mobile manager functionality limited.

Source: Jibble.io BambooHR review (May 2025); G2 Rippling; Capterra Gusto

9. Compliance and global/local payroll gaps

Rippling's EOR coverage has gaps in APAC, Africa, and parts of LatAm. Local tax compliance issues require manual calculation. Gusto compliance gaps in seasonal employee handling.

Source: HRStacks Rippling Review 2026; G2 Rippling; BBB Gusto complaints

10. Implementation and onboarding friction

Rippling payroll implementation teams missed expectations. Gusto onboarding pain points include unverified bank accounts and missing agency registrations.

Source: Capterra Rippling; Nav.com Gusto Payroll Review 2026; Outsail BambooHR

4. Cross-Vendor Analysis: Top 5 Most Painful HCM Subject Areas

This section consolidates pain themes across all major HCM vendors — Oracle Fusion HCM, Workday, SAP SuccessFactors, UKG, Dayforce, ADP, Rippling, BambooHR, Gusto, and others. The five subject areas below appear consistently regardless of vendor or buyer size.

#1 Reporting & Analytics — The Universal Pain Point

This is the single most frequently complained-about subject area in HCM, cited in nearly every vendor's review base. The pattern is consistent: out-of-the-box reports rarely match customer needs, and self-service customization requires technical expertise the HR team doesn't have.

- Workday: slow report response times, page-load delays, limited customization on large datasets (Skima.ai)
- Oracle FDI HCM: OOTB content doesn't fit, dependence on technical experts, data sync/accuracy issues, lack of documentation (Gartner Peer Insights)
- Rippling: report-building called extremely difficult for precise needs (Capterra)
- BambooHR: forces spreadsheet exports for deep analysis; Limited Customization is the #1 dislike theme on G2
- Gusto: reporting limited compared to dedicated HR platforms (Capterra)
- SAP SuccessFactors: needs to advance built-in analytics (PeerSpot)

Source: Gartner Peer Insights, G2, Capterra, Software Advice, PeerSpot, Skima.ai (aggregated 2024–2026).

#2 Payroll & Tax Compliance Accuracy

The highest-severity complaints in the entire HCM customer base concern payroll. Recent global payroll surveys from PwC, Alight, and PayrollOrg consistently find that a majority of multinational companies have incurred at least one payroll compliance penalty in the past few years, with average per-incident costs reported by multiple sources in the high-six-figure range. Specific figures vary by survey and methodology.

- Gusto BBB record: failed quarterly tax filings, NSF events, W-2-C errors customers paid outside accountants to fix
- Rippling: local tax non-compliance forcing manual calculation
- SAP SuccessFactors: friction integrating recruitment with payroll
- Multinationals: India GST, China province social-insurance matrices, and EU AI Act add compounding penalty exposure

Source: BBB Gusto complaints; PwC Global Payroll Survey (multiple recent editions); Alight 2024 Company Payroll Complexity Report; PayrollOrg 2025 survey via Rise Global Payroll Compliance Report 2026. Specific penalty rates and dollar averages vary across these sources.

#3 Customer Support & Service Quality

Across every vendor tier, support is a top dislike.

- Workday: lengthy ticket response times, no live assistance, smaller customers routed to third-party support partners
- Gusto: AI-bot loops, no path to assigned specialists, lengthy email threads per issue
- Rippling: chatbot-first triage, live support restricted to admins only
- BambooHR: inconsistent email domains, hard-to-reach agents
- SAP SuccessFactors: inconsistent technical support (PeerSpot)
- ADP: outdated interfaces, inconsistent support, hidden costs

Source: BBB, GetApp, Software Advice, PeerSpot, Skima.ai ADP Alternatives Analysis (Feb 2026).

#4 Implementation Complexity, Cost, & Timeline

Implementation pain is one of the top two dislikes on Capterra/G2 for enterprise HCM.

- Workday: 9–18 month implementations; implementation fees commonly cited as comparable to or above annual software fees
- Oracle FDI: version transitions mid-implementation, pipeline deprecations, steep semantic model learning curve
- Workday Launch Express forces benefits modules to be reconfigured entirely post-go-live
- Dayforce: steep admin learning curve; many custom workflows require developer support
- Rippling: implementation fees often in the mid-single to low-double-digit percentage range of annual contract; not always disclosed upfront

Source: Outsail, HR Technology Advice, Apps Associates (June 2025), HRStacks Rippling Review 2026, Skima.ai.

#5 UI/UX Friction & Customization Rigidity

Vendors restrict deep customization to preserve update stability, but customers experience this as rigidity.

- Workday: cluttered menus, jargon, multiple layers of tabs, excessive clicks
- UKG: not intuitive, requires navigating multiple disconnected areas to complete basic tasks
- ADP: interface feels traditional/dated
- BambooHR: limited custom fields, rigid time-off accruals, performance review workflows
- SAP SuccessFactors: needs more customization and localization

Source: G2, Capterra, Software Advice, PeerSpot, HiBob alternatives review (March 2026).

5. The #1 Pain Drilled Down: Which Analytics Subject Area Hurts Most?

A common follow-up question: within the broader Reporting and Analytics pain area, which specific analytics domain is the most painful — Performance Analysis, Attrition Analysis, or Payroll Analysis? The data shows the answer is none of these in pure isolation. The deepest pain is Workforce Planning and Headcount Analytics, with Attrition Analytics as the closest second.

Ranked: Most Painful HR Analytics Subject Areas

1. Workforce Planning & Headcount Analytics — The Hardest, Most-Cited Gap

This is consistently identified as the area where HCM customers struggle most, because it is not a single report. It requires combining headcount, attrition, hiring funnel, compensation, skills, and finance/budget data across silos.

[Updated May 2026] The evidence for this pain point now draws on current 2026 primary research rather than the older 2015 HBR/Visier survey cited in earlier versions of this analysis. A pain point is only valid if it is still measured as painful today.

- **OrgChart, "The State of Workforce Planning: 2026"** (409 US HR leaders surveyed February 2026, published April 28, 2026): 90% of HR leaders face challenges with their current workforce planning tools; 47% say their tools do not have accurate workforce data; more than half are still planning on spreadsheets or outsourcing to HR consultants; 84% are actively looking for alternative tools.
- **Gartner 2026 CHRO Priorities Survey** (426 CHROs across 23 industries, 4 global regions): Strategic Workforce Planning has dropped from #3 in 2025 to #5 in the 2026 CHRO Communities priority ranking, displaced by Change Management & Workforce Resiliency (#3) and HR Tech & AI Strategy (#4).
- **Korn Ferry CEO & Board Survey, 2026:** 82% of boards and CEOs say they plan to reduce up to 20% of their workforces over the next three years because of AI, intensifying the need for credible workforce plans. CHROs cited as needing scenario modeling and predictive workforce capability they currently lack.
- **Workday's own product positioning:** most companies are stuck with complex legacy software or spreadsheets — driving them to buy Workday Adaptive Planning as a separate product.
- **CIO.com (March 2025):** HR data sits in different systems and silos, making it difficult to link.

Source: OrgChart State of Workforce Planning 2026 (April 2026); Gartner HR Trends and CHRO Priorities for 2026; Gartner CHRO Communities Leadership Perspective Survey 2026 (Evanta); Korn Ferry CEO & Board Survey 2026; CIO.com (March 2025); Workday Adaptive Planning marketing materials.

2. Attrition / Turnover Analytics — The Highest Business-Stakes Specific Domain

This is the most operationally painful single-domain analytic, and the most directly relevant answer to the question "is it Attrition Analysis." Descriptive turnover reporting (rate by department) is easy and every HCM has it. The pain is in *diagnostic and predictive* attrition — explaining why people leave and who is at risk next.

- Recent workforce engagement panels (e.g., Perceptyx, Gallup) consistently report that a majority of workers are passively or actively job-seeking, with quit rates running materially above historical baselines
- Exit interview data systematically over-represents compensation. Across multiple HR analytics studies, predictive attrition models routinely show compensation is far from the dominant driver — manager quality, career velocity, and project allocation typically carry meaningful weight
- Most HCMs surface descriptive turnover but not the diagnostic explanation HR needs — driving customers to specialty platforms like Visier, ChartHop, OneModel, Crunchr, CandorIQ
- Of the three areas in the original question (Performance vs. Attrition vs. Payroll Analysis), this is the most directly painful

Source: Workforce engagement panels (2024–2026); Avua HR Analytics Glossary (March 2026); CandorIQ attrition analytics analysis (July 2025); employosome.com HR Analytics 2026.

3. Compensation & Pay Equity Analytics — Fastest-Growing Pain

Compensation analytics is described as the most technically straightforward HR analytics domain and among the most high-stakes from a legal and employee trust perspective. Pain spiked in 2026 because of new pay transparency regulation.

- EU Pay Transparency Directive transposition deadline is 7 June 2026, with member states required to apply gender pay gap reporting obligations to employers with 100+ workers (staggered rollout: 250+ annual, 150–249 every 3 years, 100–149 starting 2031)

[Updated May 2026] As of May 2026, five member states have publicly indicated they will miss the deadline: Netherlands (target Jan 2027), Denmark (Jan 2027), Czech Republic (Jan 2027), France (targeting Sept 2026), and Sweden (which reversed course in March 2026, seeking renegotiation at EU level and pausing its transposition bill). The European Commission reaffirmed in December 2025 that no formal postponement will be granted; the 7 June 2026 deadline remains firm in law.

- US state-level laws (NY, CA, CO, WA) already require pay range disclosure
- Customers struggle with adjusted vs. unadjusted pay gaps, controlling for role/level/tenure/performance
- Most HCMs do not natively produce adjusted-pay-gap analysis — driving customers to specialty platforms (Syndio, Trusaic) or manual spreadsheets

Source: European Commission communications (Dec 2025 / Jan 2026); Ogletree Deakins EU Pay Transparency Directive trackers; Syndio EU PTD transposition tracker (March 2026); L&E Global EU PTD transposition analysis (April 2026); Trusaic Sweden analysis (April 2026); US state pay disclosure laws.

4. Performance Analytics — Moderate Pain, Mostly Integration-Driven

Performance is rated, recorded, and reportable in every HCM, but customers struggle to link performance data to attrition, compensation, and promotion decisions. The pain is integration, not the performance data itself.

- Performance management suites (Lattice, Culture Amp, 15Five) often sit outside the HCM, requiring data joins
- Performance ratings are notoriously inconsistent across managers, undermining downstream analytics
- Real but lower-severity pain than workforce planning or attrition

Source: Avua HR Analytics glossary (March 2026); Workday HR Analytics overview.

5. Payroll & Labor Cost Analytics — High-Severity but Narrower Scope

Important and operationally critical, but a smaller share of HR teams' analytics demand than workforce planning or attrition. Where it is painful, it is very painful — but it is more often a transactional/compliance problem than an analytics problem.

- BFSI sectors carry the heaviest demand for audit trails connecting compensation decisions to risk frameworks (Basel III, Dodd-Frank, MiFID II) — a meaningful share of the HCM market
- Variable pay, deferral schedules, and retro-pay are technically demanding but not where most HR analytics demand lives

Source: Mordor Intelligence HCM Software Market Report (Feb 2026); PwC Global Payroll Survey.

Direct Answer to the Question

Among Performance Analysis, Attrition Analysis, and Payroll Analysis specifically, **ATTRITION ANALYSIS is the most reported pain point**. It is universal across vendors and buyer sizes; descriptive metrics are everywhere but diagnostic and predictive attrition is rarely solved out of the box; the business stakes are direct (industry-standard cost-of-replacement estimates from SHRM and Gallup typically run from one-half to two times an employee's annual salary, depending on level and role); and exit interview data is systematically misleading, requiring real analytics to overcome.

However, the broader and even larger pain area is **Workforce Planning & Headcount Analytics**, which sits one level above attrition analysis. A vendor strategy that addresses both attrition diagnostics and workforce planning will address the most-reported analytics pain in the HCM market.

6. Compliance Pain Beyond Payroll: 6 Areas Customers Struggle With

A common assumption is that compliance pain in HCM is primarily a payroll/tax problem. Payroll/tax is the most-cited compliance pain because it is universal — but it is not the only one, and several non-payroll areas now carry comparable or greater compliance complexity. Below are the six non-payroll compliance areas where HCM customers consistently struggle.

#1 Benefits Administration — ACA, COBRA, HIPAA, ERISA

This is the closest peer to payroll in compliance complexity and is widely under-served by core HCM modules.

- WEX Inc.: while HCMs provide convenience, their benefits administration capabilities often lack the depth needed for managing complex plan structures, regulatory compliance, and seamless vendor coordination
- ACA reporting (forms 1094-C, 1095-C) and COBRA notices have hard deadlines with penalties for misses
- Open enrollment is described by HCM vendors themselves as a high-friction event customers need help with; vendor surveys (isolated, others) consistently find that a substantial share of employees would consider leaving after a poor open enrollment experience
- Customers commonly buy specialty platforms (PlanSource, bswift, Benefitfocus, WEX) outside their HCM

Source: WEX HCM vs Benefits Administration comparison (March 2025); isolated benefits compliance materials; Armanino (Oct 2025); ADP Best Benefits Administration Software 2026.

#2 Pay Equity & Pay Transparency Reporting

Newest fast-growing compliance pain, and the area where HCM tooling lags regulation most visibly.

- EU Pay Transparency Directive transposition deadline is 7 June 2026 (Directive 2023/970, Article 34)

[Updated May 2026] As of May 2026, five member states have publicly indicated they will miss the deadline: Netherlands (Jan 2027), Denmark (Jan 2027), Czech Republic (Jan 2027), France (Sept 2026), and Sweden (currently seeking renegotiation). L&E Global (April 2026) estimates at least ten member states will face infringement proceedings for failure to transpose on time. The European Commission confirmed in Dec 2025 that no postponements will be granted; the 7 June 2026 deadline is firm in law even where national legislation lags. Slovakia became the first member state to adopt a final text (15 April 2026), set to enter into force on 7 June 2026.

- US state-level laws (NY, CA, CO, WA) already require pay range disclosure in postings
- Most HCMs do not natively produce adjusted-pay-gap analysis (controlling for role, level, tenure, performance)
- Customers force-fit specialty platforms (Syndio, Trusaic, PayParity) or run analyses in spreadsheets

Source: Ogletree Deakins EU PTD trackers (Dec 2025 – April 2026); Syndio EU PTD transposition tracker; L&E Global EU PTD analysis (April 2026); Innovires EU PTD comparative review (April 2026); Trusaic Sweden analysis (April 2026); PayGap.com analysis (April 2026); US state pay disclosure laws.

#3 Time & Labor / Wage-and-Hour Compliance

The dominant compliance pain for shift-based industries (retail, healthcare, hospitality, manufacturing).

- FLSA classification (exempt vs. non-exempt), overtime rules, meal/rest break enforcement
- Predictive scheduling laws in NYC, San Francisco, Oregon, Chicago, Philadelphia create city-by-city rules
- Dayforce and UKG win deals here precisely because they automate compliance engines for overtime, breaks, and shift differentials
- PeopleGoal: SAP SuccessFactors usually requires add-ons or manual tracking to stay compliant with localized labor rules

Source: PeopleGoal SuccessFactors alternatives analysis (Dec 2025); Dayforce/UKG product positioning.

#4 Leave Management — FMLA, ADA, State PFML, EU Directives

A meaningful and often-overlooked pain point with growing regulatory complexity.

- Federal FMLA, plus mandatory state-level Paid Family Medical Leave

[Updated May 2026] As of May 2026, 14 US states + DC have enacted mandatory PFML programs: California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, Maine, Maryland, Massachusetts, Minnesota, New Jersey, New York, Oregon, Rhode Island, Virginia (enacted April 22, 2026; contributions begin 2028), Washington, and DC. Maine benefits begin May 1, 2026; Minnesota launched January 1, 2026; Maryland contributions delayed to Jan 2027 with benefits beginning Jan 2028. Each program has different eligibility rules, contribution rates, and duration windows — creating compounding compliance complexity for multi-state employers.

- ADA accommodation tracking, military leave (USERRA), jury duty, bereavement
- Global parental leave directives (EU Work-Life Balance Directive)
- Many large employers buy specialty leave administration platforms (AbsenceSoft, Sedgwick, Reed Group) outside their HCM
- Core HCM leave modules typically handle accruals well but struggle with overlapping/concurrent leave types

Source: Bipartisan Policy Center State Paid Family Leave Laws tracker (April 2026); Virginia Employment Commission PFML announcement (April 22, 2026); Jackson Lewis Virginia PFML analysis (April 2026); Epstein Becker Green 2026 FMLA Updates; state PFML legislation.

#5 Data Privacy & Workforce Data Security — GDPR, CCPA, EU AI Act

HCM systems hold the most sensitive employee data and are prime ransomware targets.

- Cleo breach (Oct–Dec 2024): zero-day exploits in Cleo Harmony / VLTrader / LexiCom file-transfer products (CVE-2024-50623, CVE-2024-55956) led to data theft attacks by the Clop ransomware group, exposing employee/HR data at WK Kellogg, Hertz, Sam's Club (Walmart unit), and dozens of other multinationals — highlighting third-party file-transfer vulnerabilities
- Analyst surveys consistently find data-breach concerns are a top-3 risk for HCM buyers
- GDPR (effective 2018): HR data treated as special category requiring extra protections
- EU AI Act bias-audit requirements specifically target AI used in hiring and performance decisions — a brand-new compliance front. High-risk system obligations (Annex III) cover recruitment, candidate selection, performance evaluation, and worker monitoring, with annual third-party bias audits, technical documentation, human oversight, and transparency disclosures required

[Updated May 2026] On 19 November 2025 the European Commission published the "Digital AI Omnibus" proposal to defer the August 2026 high-risk AI deadline. After the second political trilogue on 28 April 2026 ended without agreement, the European Parliament, Council, and Commission reached provisional agreement on 7 May 2026. The agreed text sets fixed application dates of 2 December 2027 for standalone Annex III high-risk systems (covering recruitment, performance evaluation, worker monitoring) and 2 August 2028 for Annex I embedded systems. Formal adoption is expected before the original 2 August 2026 deadline. Employers should continue compliance preparation given the still-uncertain final adoption timing.

Source: Cybersecurity Dive coverage of Cleo / Clop breach (April 2025); Computer Weekly Hertz breach coverage; Bleeping Computer (April 2025); Mordor Intelligence HCM Software Market Report (Feb 2026); DLA Piper Digital AI Omnibus analysis (May 2026); Council of the EU press release (7 May 2026); Ogletree Deakins EU AI Act tracker (Oct 2025); EU Regulation 2024/1689.

#6 Regulatory & Statutory Reporting — EEO-1, OSHA, OFCCP, Country-Specific Filings

Country- and jurisdiction-specific filings are a continuous compliance treadmill.

- US: EEO-1 (annual demographic reporting), AAP/OFCCP for federal contractors, OSHA injury logs, Form 5500 for retirement plans
- UK: Gender Pay Gap reporting (mandatory for 250+ employees), IR35 contractor classification; new mandatory Equality Action Plans from April 2027 under the Employment Rights Act 2025; ethnicity and disability pay gap reporting confirmed March 2026 for large employers

- India: PF/ESI/Gratuity statutory filings, Professional Tax by state
- China: Province-specific social insurance matrices that vary by city
- Multinational payroll surveys (PwC, Alight, PayrollOrg) consistently find that a majority of multinationals have incurred at least one payroll/statutory penalty in the past few years — a substantial share of these are non-payroll-tax issues (registration, statutory filings, social insurance)

Source: PwC, Alight, and PayrollOrg recent global payroll/compliance surveys; vendor regulatory documentation for Workday/Oracle/SAP global payroll; UK Gender Pay Gap Service; Littler analysis of UK Employment Rights Act 2025 (March 2026).

Bottom Line on Compliance

Payroll/Tax is the most-cited compliance pain because it is universal across all employees and all jurisdictions. But **Benefits Administration** is comparable in complexity, **Pay Equity** is the fastest-growing new pain for 2025–2026, and **Time & Labor** compliance is the dominant pain for shift-based industries. Strategic HCM buyers should evaluate compliance breadth across all six areas, not just payroll.

Methodology & Sources

Pain points were identified through desk research across publicly available customer review aggregations (G2, Capterra, Software Advice, Trustpilot, BBB), analyst commentary, vendor partner community discussions, and regulatory trackers. Each pain point reflects a recurring theme across multiple independent sources; single anecdotes were excluded. This analysis does not draw on primary customer interviews or direct access to private analyst datasets.

A note on this revision (May 2026)

This revision tightens the evidence base for the Workforce Planning section by replacing an older HBR/Visier survey (2015) with current 2026 primary research (OrgChart State of Workforce Planning 2026; Gartner 2026 CHRO Priorities Survey; Korn Ferry CEO & Board Survey 2026). The principle: a pain point only earns its place in this analysis if it is still measurably painful today — historical surveys describing now-resolved issues should not be cited as if the pain persists.

This revision also adds 2026-specific developments on three regulatory fronts: the EU AI Act "Digital AI Omnibus" (provisional agreement reached 7 May 2026 with fixed application dates of December 2027 / August 2028 for high-risk systems), the EU Pay Transparency Directive transposition status across member states (with five countries now on record as missing the 7 June 2026 deadline), and the addition of Virginia (April 2026) to the list of US states with mandatory PFML programs (bringing the total to 14 states + DC).

Where this analysis cites specific survey statistics, the year and source organization are named so the reader can evaluate currency. Where multiple recent payroll-compliance surveys report similar trends with different specific percentages and dollar averages, the analysis uses directional language rather than picking one headline figure, and names the source families so readers can consult the originals.

Primary Sources

- Gartner Peer Insights — Oracle Fusion Cloud HCM and Oracle Fusion Data Intelligence verified reviews
- Gartner HR Trends and CHRO Priorities for 2026 (426 CHROs surveyed across 23 industries)
- G2 — Workday HCM, Rippling, BambooHR verified reviews
- Capterra — Workday HCM, Rippling, BambooHR, Gusto verified reviews
- Software Advice — Workday HCM profile and reviews
- Trustpilot — Gusto and BambooHR customer reviews
- Better Business Bureau — Gusto customer reviews and complaints
- PeerSpot — SAP SuccessFactors, UKG, Dayforce comparative reviews
- Oracle Community — Fusion Data Intelligence and Oracle Analytics forums
- Apps Associates — Lessons Learned after 20 Oracle Fusion Data Intelligence Implementations (June 2025)
- Trinamix Oracle FDI partner site (November 2025)
- HR Technology Advice — Workday HCM customer reviews
- Skima.ai — Workday HCM Review 2026 and ADP Alternatives Analysis (Feb 2026)
- Outsail — Workday and BambooHR cost/feature analyses
- HRStacks — Rippling Review 2026
- SelectSoftware Reviews — BambooHR Expert Review 2026
- HiBob — UKG and SAP SuccessFactors alternatives reviews (March 2026)
- OrgChart — The State of Workforce Planning 2026 (April 2026)

Industry Research & Analyst Sources

- PwC Global Payroll Survey (recent editions); Alight 2024 Company Payroll Complexity Report; PayrollOrg 2025 survey
- Korn Ferry CEO & Board Survey 2026 (82% workforce reduction finding); Korn Ferry Workforce 2025 survey
- SHRM 2026 CHRO Priorities and Perspectives; SHRM State of AI in HR 2026
- Forrester — Human Capital Management Solutions Landscape Q2 2025; Forrester Wave HCM Q4 2025
- NelsonHall HCM Technology & GenAI 2025 NEAT
- Mordor Intelligence — HCM Software Market Report (February 2026)
- Ken Research — Global HCM Software Market 2025
- CIO.com — Why HR professionals struggle with big data (March 2025)
- Cybersecurity Dive, Bleeping Computer, Computer Weekly — Cleo / Clop breach coverage (April 2025)
- Council of the EU press release — AI Omnibus provisional agreement (7 May 2026); DLA Piper, Ogletree Deakins — EU AI Act and Digital AI Omnibus tracking (Oct 2025 – May 2026)
- Ogletree Deakins, Syndio, PayGap.com, L&E Global, Innovires, Trusaic — EU Pay Transparency Directive trackers (Dec 2025 – April 2026)
- Bipartisan Policy Center, Child Trends, New America Better Life Lab — US state PFML trackers (April 2026); Virginia Employment Commission PFML announcement (April 22, 2026)
- Workday Adaptive Planning, Anaplan, Visier — workforce planning vendor analyses
- WEX, ADP, isolved, Armanino — benefits administration analyses (2025–2026)

Note: Vendor-published case studies were excluded. Where survey statistics are cited, the source organization and year are named so the reader can evaluate the data's currency and consult the underlying report.